> We have recently seen credible reports in the international media on the Taliban handing over terrorist training facilities to the Harkat-ul-Ansar. It is reported that at these training camps Pakistani and other youth are being trained for terrorist activities in Kashmir.[172]

Just before this debate, the then PM H. D. Deve Gowda met Rabbani at the World Food Summit in Rome, following which India sent a delegation to Mazar-e-Sharif led by the MEA's Secretary (East) on 10 November 1996 to meet Dostum and discuss the modalities of cooperation. Iran and Russia were informed that India would continue to maintain contact with the 'legitimate' Afghan government. While stating that 'there could be no military solution', New Delhi made no bones about signaling where its heart lay when Gujral said that 'a complete cessation of foreign interference' was a 'prerequisite for the resolution of the situation'.[173] Soon after, India activated aid and arms supplies to the UF in concert with Russia and Iran.[174]

Spy talk

Partisan narratives emerging from the MEA and the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) in 1996–97 had support from India's military and intelligence agencies as well. Consideration of this community's advocacy is critical given its involvement in the Baloch and Pashtun separatist movements in Pakistan (even though some Indian intelligence analysts note, inaccurately, that Rao and Gujral systematically scrapped India's covert coercive capabilities in the 1990s).[175] Even David Sedney, former US Deputy Assistant Secretary of Defence for Afghanistan, Pakistan and Central Asia says that 'India may not have done all the things Pakistan says it does till now [2014], but they may start doing that in future'.[176] What then did Indian spymasters and military officials think? According to a top Indian military intelligence officer closely following Afghanistan: 'Indians had nothing to do with the Taliban … and Pakistan made sure that we have no connections with the Pashtuns.'[177] This was, at a minimum, one reason why India could not properly assess the possibility of collaborating, if need be, with the Taliban on the Durand Line issue. The official adds somewhat caustically:

> We're fascinated by the Pashtuns but they have done nothing for us. When they have a choice to make between Pakistan and India then they may not side with us. Any intelligence agency [read R&AW] that says that they have contacts and leeway among Pashtuns—they are cheating themselves.[178]